THE SHIFT TO PRIVATE VEHICLES

The share of bus travel for overnight trips has declined sharply over a decade. Meanwhile, reliance on own transport has more than tripled

2025-2026 2014-2015



Bus
46.8 | 65.3



Train
11.3 | 12.8



Own motorised transport
30.1 | 9.6

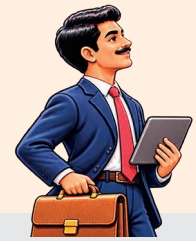


Hired motorised transport
10.6 | 8.4

RETREAT OF THE BUS

Fewer people use buses than a decade ago, signalling a clear preference for other modes of transport

2025-2026 2014-2015



Business
34.2 | 46.7



Social
47.1 | 67.4



Education & Training
52.7 | 54.1

Source: Domestic Tourism in India 2014-15 and Domestic Tourism Expenditure Survey 2025-26; figures in %

In 2014-15, the survey tracked 'discretionary consumer tourism' (holidaying, medical and shopping) over a full 365-day window. It tracked religious, social and business travel exclusively over a shorter 30-day window. In 2025-26, it shifted the framework, grouping holidaying, medical, shopping, and religious travel into a single 365-day reference period

THE GREAT TRANSPORT PARADOX

India's most widely used mode of transport is losing ground as underfunded bus services, poor connectivity and fragmented planning drive commuters towards private vehicles

One of the highlights of India's development story over the past decade is the sheer amount of money pumped into building expressways, railways, airports and metros. Millions use them, certainly. But as the latest government surveys reveal, the mode of transport on which Indians depend most for long-distance travel remains the humble bus.

According to the National Household Travel Survey (NHTS) 2025-26, as many as 55.8 per cent of households reporting overnight travel used buses as a primary mode of transport, compared with 17.7 per cent using intercity rail and just 0.6 per cent travelling by air. Bus use was higher in rural areas at 59.3 per cent, against 51.1 per cent in urban areas.

5
PER CENT
of India's urban workers commute by monorail, metro, suburban rail and trams, according to the National Household Travel Survey, 2025-26

Another government survey reveals a significant shift that ostensibly swings the other way—but is a classic instance of policy guiding choice.. The Domestic Tourism Expenditure Survey (DTES) 2025-26 recorded buses as the major mode for only 46.8 per cent of overnight visitor-trips in its 30-day reference group in 2025-26, compared with 65.3 per cent in 2014-15. Own motorised transport accounted for 30.1 per cent, against 9.6 per cent previously. The comparison is for a particular category of overnight travel, rather than all journeys.

Higher incomes have brought wider car ownership. When buses are infrequent, unreliable or poorly linked, a private vehicle becomes a more appealing choice for those who can afford it. And those who cannot, but must. "You need to give strategic levers to people to actually shift to public transit," says Anurag Gupta, partner, Deloitte India. "They don't want to stand in lines. They don't want to walk two kilometres or take a rickshaw. So quality becomes equally important, if we have to make our public transit more efficient. This survey, for the first time, brings out